

Clayton Glazier
LIS 510
02/23/2026

CrowdStrike Post-Mortem

Early 2024:

Introduction of the new IPC Template type for Windows sensors. Passed existing validation processes, but a bug was later found in the Content Validator that failed to catch malinformed data.

July 19, 2024:

4:09 UTC - Faculty Rapid Response Content deployed to Windows sensors. Windows endpoints begin crashing, Azure VMs and enterprise systems fail globally.

4:15 - 5:00 UTC - Customer reports spike. Telemetry shows correlation with newly deployed IPC Templates.

5:27 UTC - CrowdStrike rolls back the content update globally. Many machines require manual reboots or repeated restart cycles, while some endpoints need remediation. CrowdStrike announces that the issue is not a cyberattack.

Delta Air Lines Post-Mortem

July 19:

Early morning - Airport workstations begin failing.

3:54 EDT - Delta pauses all flights globally due to tech issues.

Morning - Afternoon - 1,000+ cancellations, use of manual workarounds, and issuance of travel waivers.

July 20-25:

Ongoing cancellations while systems are restored.

Hundreds of millions in revenue impacted.

CrowdStrike Crucial Moment - The 5:27 UTC rollbacks

Cues:

Spike in sensor crashes after content rollout.

Logs tie the crashes to the new content file.

Interpretation:

A parsing or validation issue.

Global issue due to broad deployment.

The need to pause rollouts to reduce risk.

Goals:

Stop harm and restore stability while communicating transparently and quickly. This made sense because rolling back the content was the quickest way to contain the issue.

Delta Air Lines Crucial Moment - 3:54 EDT global flight pause

Cues:

Endpoint failures at gates and operational centers.

Vendor outrage which affected global systems.

Interpretation:

The need to pause departures to reduce risk.

Outage appears systemic, not local.

Goals:

Maintain safety.

Prevent compounding risk and chaos.

Stabilize systems before resuming departures.

Taking Action:

Pause departures.

Issue waivers and communication.

Begin manual fallback procedures.

Help

Internal IT and crew operations.

Vendors.

CrowdStrike Reflect

The rapid detection through telemetry worked.

The rollbacks were quick and only took about 80 minutes.

Communication was clear that this was not a cyberattack.

Validator bugs allowed malformed content

Industry dependence increased systemic impact

Delta Air Lines Reflect

Safety first decisions.

Rapid Communication and waivers.

Heavy dependence on digital systems.

Limited manual modes for crew/gate operations.

CrowdStrike Improve

Improve content validation.

Delta Air Lines Improve

Develop manual modes with local systems for crew/gate operations.

Conduct regular digital outage drills

CrowdStrike System Change

Required staged deployment with automatic thresholds rollback before global use.

Delta Air Lines System Change

Develop and routinely practice an operational fallback mode for crew tracking and gate controls through local systems.